THE TOWN OF CORTE MADERA
MARIN COUNTY CALIFORNIA

CORTE MADERA TOWN COUNCIL
STAFF REPORT

REPORT DATE: May 20, 2026
MEETING DATE: June 02, 2026

TO: Honorable Mayor and Members of the Town Council

FROM: Ruben Martin, Fire Chief

Adam Wolff, Town Manager

SUBJECT: Adoption of Resolution No. 24/2026 1) Calling for and Giving Notice of the Holding of the General Municipal Election on November 3, 2026 for a Ballot Measure Imposing and Extending the Special Parcel Tax for Paramedic Services; and (2) Requesting that the Board of Supervisors of the County of Marin Consolidate Said Election with the General Election to be Held on the Same Date and Requesting Election Services by the Marin County Elections Department

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RECOMMENDATION:

Adopt Resolution No. 24/2026 calling and giving notice of the holding of an election to be held on November 3, 2026, and request the Board of Supervisors of the County of Marin consolidate said election; and authorize the Clerk or her duly authorized officers and agency to carry out all the necessary procedures for said election submitting to the voters the question relating to a special tax for paramedic services.

BACKGROUND:

In 1983, Corte Madera residents approved a special tax for paramedic and emergency medical services. The tax was originally raised as a part of the Ross Valley Paramedic Authority (RVPA). The RVPA is an 8-member joint powers authority that was established in 1982 for the purpose of delivering fire department paramedic services in the Ross Valley region. The RVPA provided a single ambulance, staffed with two paramedics. The ambulance was stationed in the Town of Ross. Due to the geographic location of the ambulance and the call volume throughout the Ross Valley region, response times to Corte Madera were longer than those of the other areas served.

Through the combination of this special tax and transport billing services, the Town raised the necessary revenue to provide paramedic service within the Town of Corte Madera through the cross training of fire department personnel and the implementation of an Advanced Life Support (ALS) level ambulance service. The Town of Corte Madera provided this service in conjunction with and as a subcontractor to

the Ross Valley Paramedic Authority (RVPA). Since the addition of this resource in 1998, ALS response times to locations within Corte Madera have been greatly improved. In addition, the greater Ross Valley region is now served by two ALS fire-based paramedic ambulances. Both units provide back up for the other, greatly reducing the need for more distant mutual aid or the reliance on private providers, whose availability fluctuates greatly.

In Corte Madera, the current tax generated approximately $525,000 in revenue during fiscal year 2025/2026, which was entirely allocated toward the funding of EMS services. During the four-year cycle of the current tax, costs have increased across all sectors of the EMS delivery system. Examples include required technology such as defibrillators with wireless transmitting capability, LUCAS cardiopulmonary resuscitation (CPR) machines, electronic patient care records, emergency medicines, disposable medical supplies, personnel costs, etc. These system-wide cost increases have compelled the need to consider renewing the tax at an increased rate.

DISCUSSION:

Special Tax

The primary funding mechanism for providing Paramedic Advanced Life Support services to the Town of Corte Madera is a parcel tax. Each taxable residential unit is taxed along with every 1,000 square feet of non-residential structures. This special tax-funding structure has been in place since 1983 has provided a portion of the approximately $6.3 million annual budget contribution (FY 26/27) the Town makes to Central Marin Fire Authority to provide paramedic services.

Every four years, the citizens of Corte Madera vote to fund the tax for a four-year period. The current tax expires on June 30, 2027. In order to maintain this revenue and the current level of advanced life support (ALS Ambulance and Paramedic Engine Companies), the Town must place the matter on the November 3, 2026 ballot. The Town of Corte Madera has moved to even year elections per SB 415, which is a much less expensive election option since it is consolidated with the statewide elections.

Under California Law, towns and cities may impose special taxes only when the measure is approved by 2/3 of the voters voting in the election. (Cal. Gov. Code § 53722; see also Cal. Gov. Code § 50077(a)).

In November 2022, the Town proposed, and the voters approved by 81%, the current tax, which will be set at $87 for each residential unit or $87 for each one thousand square feet of nonresidential use in FY 2026/27.

For the next four years, beginning in FY 2027/28, the following is the proposed tax rate containing up to a $7.50 increase in 2027/28 and up to a $7.75 annual increase from 2028/29-2020/31 as follows:

2027/28	$94.50
2028/29	$102.25
2029/30	$110.00
2030/31	$117.75

Background information on the tax rate increase can be found in Agenda item 6.A. of the May 19th Town

Council meeting and via the discussion of the item which can be watched and listened to here.

Proposed Ballot Language

> *"To maintain rapid 9-1-1 emergency response times and preserve the number of on-duty paramedics ready to respond to accidents/medical emergencies, shall the Ross Valley Paramedic Authority measure be adopted continuing for four years the paramedic services special tax of up to $94.50/ residential living unit or 1,000 square feet of developed nonresidential property, adjusted up to $7.75/ year, generating approximately $786,000 annually, with annual audits, public spending disclosure and all funds for local paramedic services?"*

The Town of Corte Madera as a sub-contractor to the RVPA through the Central Marin Fire Authority has provided excellent paramedic services to the residents of Corte Madera since 1998 (since 1983 as part of RVPA Tax Measure) and the actions requested of the Town Council would be to place a measure on the ballot to continue those services for another four years.

Election

According to the Marin Registrar of Voters, the cost to place an item on the consolidated general election ballot ranges from $19,000 to $38,000 or approximately $3.00 per registered voter depending on the number of items on the ballot and the number of jurisdictions who participate in the election.

Election Timing

Dates	Deadlines
August 7th	Last day to file resolution consolidating election
August 17th	Deadline for submission of primary arguments to Town Clerk and for receipt of Town Attorney's analysis.
August 24th	Deadline for submission of rebuttal arguments to Town Clerk.

Campaign

It is important for the Town Council to keep in mind that public resources may not be used for ballot measure campaign activities. If the Council adopts the attached resolution to put the measure on the November 3, 2026, ballot, Town officials may not engage in campaign activities while on Town time or use Town resources to advocate for the measure.

WORK PLAN:

This item is not associated with the current Staff Work Plan.

FISCAL IMPACT:

The placement of the ordinance on the ballot will cost the Town approximately $3.00 per registered

voter, or approximately $18,600. The Town has budgeted enough funds for the elections in the general fund to cover the cost of this election.

If the tax does not continue for any reason, the Town and Central Marin Fire Authority will have a difficult time providing paramedic services to the citizens of the Town of Corte Madera.

ENVIRONMENTAL IMPACT:

Adoption of the attached resolution is exempt from the California Environmental Quality Act, Public Resources Code section 21000 et seq. ("CEQA"), because it can be seen with certainty that there is no possibility that the activity authorized herein may have a significant effect on the environment. (CEQA Guidelines §15061(b)(3)).

ATTACHMENTS:

1. Proposed Resolution No. 24/2026 with Exhibit A: Draft Ordinance No. __/2026 Imposing and Extending a Special Tax for Paramedic and/or Emergency Medical Services
2. Ballot Argument for Paramedic Tax Renewal

ATTACHMENT 1

Proposed Resolution No. 24/2026 with Exhibit A: Draft Ordinance No. __/2026 Imposing and Extending a Special Tax for Paramedic and/or Emergency Medical Services

RESOLUTION NO. 24/2026

A RESOLUTION OF THE TOWN COUNCIL OF TOWN OF CORTE MADERA CALLING FOR A MUNICIPAL ELECTION TO BE HELD IN ITS JURISDICTION ON NOVEMBER 3, 2026, FOR THE PURPOSE OF SUBMITTING TO THE VOTERS A MEASURE AUTHORIZING THE CONTINUATION OF A SPECIAL PARCEL TAX FOR PARAMEDIC SERVICES AND REQUESTING THE MARIN COUNTY BOARD OF SUPERVISORS TO CONSOLIDATE SAID ELECTION WITH THE GENERAL ELECTION CONDUCTED ON THAT DATE

WHEREAS, the Ross Valley Paramedic Authority ("RVPA") is an eight member California Joint Powers Authority formed by agreement in 1982 pursuant to the California Joint Exercise of Powers Act, Gov. Code, §§ 6500 *et seq.*, by and among the Cities/Towns of Corte Madera, Larkspur, Fairfax, Ross, and San Anselmo; the Kentfield Fire Protection District; the Sleepy Hollow Fire Protection District; and the County of Marin ("Member Agencies") for the purpose of providing paramedic and pre-hospital emergency medical services throughout and across the Member Agencies' jurisdictional boundaries by a single, consolidated agency; and

WHEREAS, the Town of Corte Madera has been a Member Agency of RVPA since its inception over 40 years ago; and

WHEREAS, the community has consistently received responsive, high-quality paramedic and pre-hospital emergency medical care from RVPA and the Town Council of the Town of Corte Madera wishes to maintain and ensure this service into the future; and

WHEREAS, RVPA is funded largely with tax revenues from its Member Agencies; and

WHEREAS, a statewide election will be held on November 3, 2026 ("General Election"); and

WHEREAS, California Government Code section 53722 allows the Town of Corte Madera to submit to the voters a proposition for the imposition of a special tax to be approved by a two-thirds vote of the voters voting in an election on the issue; and

WHEREAS, the voters of the Town of Corte Madera have consistently voted in favor of the RVPA special tax for paramedic services and last approved such a tax in 2022; and

WHEREAS, the monies from the RVPA special tax are used exclusively for paramedic and pre-hospital emergency care services; and

WHEREAS, through the adoption of this Resolution, the Town Council of the Town of Corte Madera desires to propose to its voters the renewal of an additional four years of the special tax in the amounts specified in the Ordinance attached hereto, at the November 3, 2026 election; and

WHEREAS, pursuant to California Elections Code sections 10403 *et seq.*, the Town Council of the Town of Corte Madera may request consolidation of the election with any and all other elections to be held on November 3, 2026, and may request that the Marin County Registrar of Voters perform certain election services; and

WHEREAS, the Town of Corte Madera desires that the election on the special tax measure be consolidated with the statewide General Election to be held on November 3, 2026.

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED as follows:

SECTION 1. RECITALS. The above recitals are true and correct and incorporated as findings herein.

SECTION 2. ELECTION CALLED. There is hereby called and ordered to be held in the Town of Corte Madera of California on Tuesday, November 3, 2026, a General Municipal Election to submit to the voters the Ordinance, continuing a special parcel tax for the provision of paramedic and emergency medical services. The Ordinance is attached hereto as Exhibit "A" and incorporated herein by reference.

SECTION 3. BALLOT QUESTION. The special parcel tax measure shall be submitted to the voters on the ballot in the form of the following question:

To maintain rapid 9-1-1 emergency response times and preserve the number of on-duty paramedics ready to respond to accidents/medical emergencies, shall the Ross Valley Paramedic Authority measure be adopted continuing for four years the paramedic services special tax of up to $94.50/ residential living unit or 1,000 square feet of developed nonresidential property, adjusted up to $7.75/ year, generating approximately $786,000 annually, with annual audits, public spending disclosure and all funds for local paramedic services?	Yes No

SECTION 4. APPROVAL OF ORDINANCE. The Town Council of Town of Corte Madera hereby approves the Ordinance, the form thereof, and its submission to the voters at the November 3, 2026 election, as attached hereto as Exhibit "A" incorporated herein by reference. The measure shall not take effect unless and until approved by a vote of at least two-thirds of the voters voting on the question at the election.

SECTION 5. IMPARTIAL ANALYSIS. The Town of Corte Madera Town Attorney is hereby directed to prepare an impartial analysis of the ballot measure showing the effect of the measure on the existing law and operation of the measure.

SECTION 6. BALLOT ARGUMENT. Pursuant to Article 4, Chapter 3, Division 9 of the Elections Code, an argument in favor of the ballot measure shall be submitted on behalf of the Town of Corte Madera. The deadline to file arguments for or against the measure is August 17, 2026. Arguments shall be submitted to the Town Clerk of the Town of Corte Madera and shall not exceed 300 words in length. The clerk upon receipt of arguments, and after the filing deadline, shall immediately transmit copies to any known opposing parties who may then submit rebuttals. If one or more arguments are submitted in favor or against the measure, arguments shall be selected pursuant to Elections Code section 9287, and if more than one argument shares the same priority, random selection shall be used.

SECTION 7. REBUTTAL ARGUMENT. The last day for filing rebuttal arguments shall be August 24, 2026, with the Town Clerk of the Town of Corte Madera and shall not exceed 250 words in length. Pursuant to Elections Code section 9285(a), when the arguments for and against the measure have been selected, the Town Clerk shall send a copy of the argument in favor of the measure to the authors of the argument against the measure, and a copy of an argument against the measure to the authors of the argument in favor of the measure.

SECTION 8. BALLOT FORMAT. The ballots to be used at the election shall be in the form and content as required by law.

SECTION 9. HOURS OF POLLING. The polls for the election shall be opened at 7:00 a.m. on the day of the election, and shall remain open continuously until 8:00 p.m. of the same day at such time when the polls shall be closed.

SECTION 10. REQUESTING CONSOLIDATION OF ELECTIONS. Pursuant to Elections Code section 10403, the Board of Supervisors of the County of Marin is hereby requested to consolidate the General Municipal Election on Tuesday, November 3, 2026 with the statewide General Election to be held on the same date, provide all services necessary for this election, and print ballots including the ballot measure set forth herein. The election shall be conducted in all respects as if one election, and one form of ballot shall be used.

SECTION 11. NOTICE TO COUNTY OF MARIN. The Town Clerk is hereby authorized and directed to file a certified copy of this Resolution with the Marin County Board of Supervisors and the Registrar of the County of Marin, pursuant to Elections Code section 10403.

SECTION 12. NOTICE OF ELECTION. The Town Clerk is hereby authorized and directed to give notice of the election as required by law.

SECTION 13. CERTIFICATION. The Town Clerk shall certify to the passage and adoption of this Resolution and enter it into the book of original resolutions.

SECTION 14. EXECUTION. The Town Manager of the Town of Coret Madera is hereby authorized and directed to do any and all things necessary to execute and deliver any and all documents necessary or advisable in order to complete the process for placing the measure on the November 3, 2026 ballot.

SECTION 15. SEVERABILITY. If any section, subsection, sentence, clause, phrase, or portion of this Resolution is for any reason held to be invalid or unconstitutional by the decision of any court, such decision shall not affect the validity of the remaining portions of this Resolution. The [council] hereby declares that it would have adopted this Resolution and each section, subsection, sentence, clause, and phrase irrespective of the fact that any one or more of same be declared invalid and unconstitutional.

RESOLUTION PASSED AND ADOPTED, at a meeting of the Town Council of the Town of Corte Madera on the 2nd day of June 2026 by the following vote:

AYES: Councilmembers:
NOES: Councilmembers:
ABSENT: Councilmembers:

APPROVED:

_____
Rosa Thomas, Mayor

ATTEST:

_____
Lorena Barrera, Town Clerk

ORDINANCE NO. __/2026

AN ORDINANCE OF THE TOWN OF CORTE MADERA
IMPOSING AND EXTENDING A SPECIAL TAX FOR
PARAMEDIC AND/OR EMERGENCY MEDICAL SERVICES

The people of the Town of Corte Madera do ordain as follows:

Section 1: Chapter 3.50 of the Town of Corte Madera Municipal Code is hereby amended to read as follows:

Chapter 3.50

CORTE MADERA PARAMEDIC AND/OR EMERGENCY MEDICAL SERVICES TAX

3.50.010 Authority, purpose and intent.
3.50.020 Definitions.
3.50.030 Tax imposed.
3.50.040 Use of tax proceeds, appropriations limit.
3.50.050 Method of collection.
3.50.060 Delinquency.
3.50.070 Amendment of chapter.
3.50.080 Severability.
3.50.090 Two-thirds voter approval, effective date.
3.50.100 Sunset provision.
3.50.110 Execution.

3.50.010 Authority, purpose and intent. It is the sole purpose and intent of this chapter, pursuant to Article XI of the California Constitution to impose a special tax on residential and nonresidential property within the Town of Corte Madera (Town), the proceeds of which shall be used exclusively to fund paramedic and/or emergency medical services. This parcel tax is neither an ad valorem tax on real property nor a transaction or sales tax on the sale of property. It is an excise tax on the privilege of using District services. It is a special tax and requires two-thirds voter approval.

3.50.020 Definitions. The definitions given in this section shall govern the construction of this chapter.

(1) Floor area. "Floor area" shall be defined as the total enclosed area of all floors of a building measured to the outside face of the walls.

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(2) Nonresidential Use. "Nonresidential use" shall be defined as any building which is designed, intended, or used for any purpose other than a residential use, including, but not limited to, commercial, industrial and office uses. A hotel, motel and all residential units contained therein, as defined below, shall be treated as a nonresidential use.

(3) Residential Unit. "Residential unit" shall be defined as each building or portion thereof, containing one or more rooms, a separate bathroom, and a single kitchen, as defined in Section 18.04.400 of the Corte Madera Municipal Code, designed for or occupied by one family or by one or more individuals.

3.50.030 Tax imposed. A special tax for the purpose outlined in Section 3.50.040 shall be imposed on nonresidential uses and on residential units in the amount specified below for each of the fiscal years 2027-2028 to 2030-2031.

(1) Nonresidential uses:

Ninety-four dollars and fifty cents ($94.50 to a maximum of $117.75) per year for each 1,000 square feet of floor area.

(2) Residential Units:

Ninety-four dollars and fifty cents ($94.50 to a maximum of $117.75) per year for each residential unit.

3.50.040 Limitation on use of tax proceeds. The proceeds of the special tax imposed by this chapter shall be deposited into a special fund in the Town treasury and used specifically and solely for the purpose of providing paramedic and/or emergency medical services. This limitation on the use of the proceeds shall be legally binding and enforceable.

3.50.045 Appropriations limit. The appropriations limit of the Town shall be increased by the proceeds received from this special tax for each of the four years of this special tax to permit the expenditure of the proceeds of the tax imposed by this Ordinance for the specific and limited purposes set forth in section 3.50.40.

3.50.050 Method of collection. The special tax imposed by this chapter shall be due from every person who owns real property within the Town on which is located a residential unit(s) and/or a nonresidential use(s) and as reflected upon the rolls of the Marin County Assessor at the same time ad valorem tax is due. This special tax shall be collected by the Marin County Tax Collector at the same time, in the same manner, and subject to the same terms and conditions, including penalties and interest, as the ad valorem tax. The full amount due under this chapter shall constitute a debt to the Town. An action for the collection of any tax due hereunder may be commenced in the name of the Town, or its assignee, in any court having jurisdiction of the cause.

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3.50.055 Accountability report. The Town Treasurer shall prepare and file with the City Council a report by August 1st of each year stating: (a) the amounts collected and spent by the Town in the previous fiscal year, (b) the status of services authorized to be funded by the proceeds of this tax, and (c) the funds carried over from previous years and to be carried over to future years. Such report shall be available for inspection without charge to any property owner in the Town.

B To any amount of the tax created by this chapter which becomes delinquent, the Marin County Tax Collector shall add a penalty in an amount equal to any penalty owing for delinquencies in the ad valorem property tax. The tax and penalty shall bear interest at the same rate as the rate for unpaid ad valorem tax until paid.

3.50.065 Refunds. Whenever the amount of any tax, penalty, or interest imposed by this Ordinance has been paid more than once, or has been erroneously or illegally collected or received by the Town, it may be refunded provided a verified claim in writing therefor, stating the specific ground upon which such claim is founded, is filed with the Treasurer within one (1) year of the date of payment. The claim shall be filed by the person who paid the tax or such person's guardian, conservator, or the executor of her or his estate and shall contain the information required by Government Code section 910 for claims to which that section applies. No claim may be filed on behalf of other taxpayers or a class of taxpayers. If a claim is approved by the Town Council, the excess may be refunded or may be credited against any amounts then due and payable from the person from whom it was collected, and the balance may be refunded to such person, his/her administrators or executors. Filing a timely and sufficient claim shall be a condition precedent to legal action against the Town for a refund of the tax.

3.50.070 Amendment of chapter. The Town Council is hereby authorized to amend this chapter by three (3) affirmative votes of its members for the sole and limited purposes of carrying out the general purposes of this chapter, to conform the provisions of this chapter to applicable state law, to permit the County Tax Collector to collect the special tax levied by this chapter, or to re-assign the duties of public officials under this chapter. In no event, however, may the Town Council increase the tax amount specified in Section 3.50.030 or modify the specific and limited purposes for which the tax may be utilized as provided for in Section 3.50.040 without the approval of two-thirds of the voters of the Town voting on the question.

3.50.080 Severability. If any section, or part thereof, of this chapter is held invalid or unenforceable by any court and such judgment becomes final, then that section, or part thereof, may be amended by this Council, by a majority vote, to conform with the judgment of such court, provided such amendment is consistent with the purpose and intent of this chapter. If any section, subsection, sentence, phrase or clause of this chapter is for any reason held to be invalid, such decision shall not affect the validity of the remaining portion of this chapter. The People of the Town of Corte Madera hereby declare that they would have adopted this chapter and each section, subsection, sentence, phrase or clause thereof irrespective of the fact that any one or more sections, subsections, sentences, phrases, or clauses may be declared invalid.

3.50.090 Two-thirds approval, effective date. An election to confirm and approve this Ordinance has been set for November 3, 2026. This ordinance shall be effective only if

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approved by two-thirds (2/3) of the voters voting upon this Ordinance and shall go into effect ten (10) days after the vote is declared by the Town Council.

3.50.100 Sunset provision. This Ordinance shall expire and be of no further force or effect after midnight, June 30, 2031.

3.50.110 Execution. The Town Mayor is hereby authorized to attest to the adoption of this Ordinance by signing where indicated below.

I certify that the foregoing Ordinance was PASSED, APPROVED and ADOPTED by the people of the Town of Corte Madera voting on the 3rd day of November 2026.

AYES: Councilmembers:
NOES: Councilmembers:
ABSENT: Councilmembers:
RECUSED: Councilmembers:

APPROVED:

_____
Rosa Thomas, Mayor

ATTEST:

_____
Lorena Barrera, Town Clerk

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ATTACHMENT 2

Ballot Argument for Paramedic Tax Renewal

ARGUMENT IN FAVOR OF MEASURE __

Vote Yes on _ to maintain rapid 9-1-1 emergency response times in Corte Madera.

Since 1983 Corte Madera voters have overwhelmingly supported local voter-approved funding for paramedic services. Unless renewed by voters, this funding will expire next year and local paramedic services must be reduced.

Voting Yes on _ renews local paramedic funding for four more years at the current tax rate with modest annual increases of no more than $7.75 per year.

Voting Yes on _ will:

- Maintain rapid 9-1-1 emergency response times
- Preserve the number of on- duty paramedics ready to respond to accidents and medical emergencies
- Maintain access to lifesaving emergency medical training and equipment for local paramedics – including Advanced Life Support

Measure_ continues fiscal accountability and local control:

- All funds must stay in Corte Madera for paramedic services only and cannot be diverted
- No funds can be taken away by the state or federal governments
- Annual audits and public spending disclosure ensure funds are spent as promised

Local paramedic care is provided through state-of-the-art paramedic ambulance units with trained paramedics aboard fire engines so that advanced emergency care arrives as quickly as possible. While paramedic services are partially funded by collections from insurance companies and billing of nonresidents, the current level of service cannot continue without Measure_.

For victims of heart attacks, strokes, accidents, and other emergencies, rapid 9-1-1 paramedic response can be the difference between life and death. You never know when an accident or medical emergency will occur. Vote Yes on _ to ensure rapid 9-1-1 paramedic response is ready when you or a loved one needs it the most.